

Post-incident review PIR-2025-016

Notification Service: stale data shown to users

Contoso Platform Engineering. Fictional sample data.

Summary

On 19 September 2025, Notification Service experienced stale data shown to users in production (US West) for about 110 minutes. The first signal was a spike in support tickets from merchants. Investigation found that the database ran out of connections under end-of-month batch load.

Impact

Users of Notification Service saw stale data shown to users for about 110 minutes. The service owner, Messaging, led the response.

Timeline

- 09:02 First signal received.
- 09:21 Incident declared and on-call team engaged.
- 09:58 Likely cause identified.
- 10:25 Mitigation applied.
- 10:34 Service confirmed healthy and incident closed.

What happened

Investigation found that the database ran out of connections under end-of-month batch load.

The expected load had not been tested before release.

There was no documented procedure for this failure mode, so responders worked it out live.

What went well

Responders communicated clearly in the incident channel and the status page was updated within fifteen minutes of the incident being declared.

Actions

- Move certificate renewal into the automated rotation pipeline.
- Review alert thresholds so the alert only fires when action is needed.
- Assign a named owner for the component in the service catalogue.